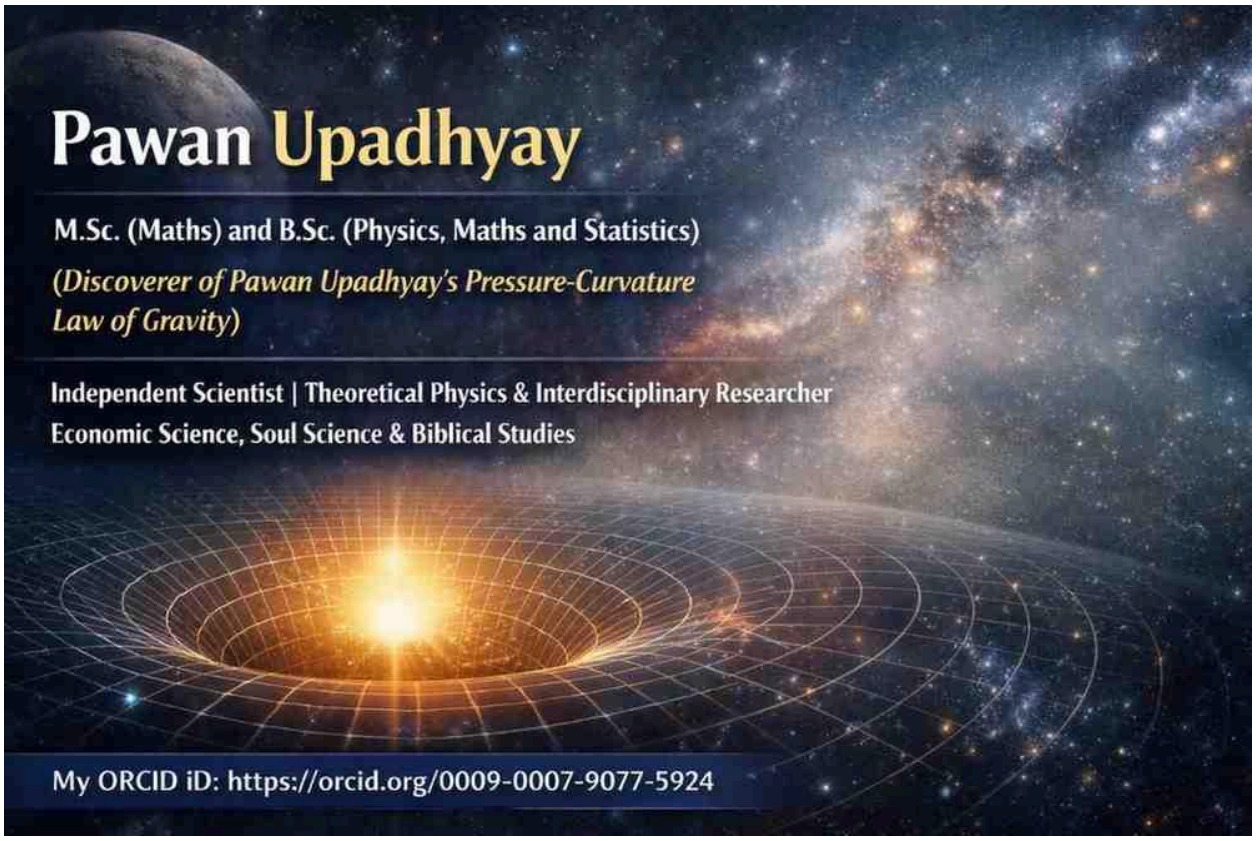
Bless and Blessed

A Comparative Word Study in English, Hebrew, Greek, and Aramaic

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Abstract

The biblical concepts of **"bless"** and **"blessed"** are central to Scripture, appearing in creation, covenant, worship, wisdom literature, the Psalms, the prophetic writings, the New Testament, and the teaching of Jesus. Yet the English words *bless* and *blessed* represent several different Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek terms whose meanings overlap without being identical.

This study examines the principal vocabulary associated with “bless” and “blessed” in **English, Biblical Hebrew, Aramaic/Syriac, and Biblical Greek**. Particular attention is given to the Hebrew **בָּרַךְ (*bārak*)**, the Hebrew **אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*)**, the Greek **εὐλογέω (*eulogeō*)**, **εὐλογία (*eulogia*)**, and **μακάριος (*makarios*)**, and the Aramaic/Syriac **ברך (*brk*)**, **בריך (*brīkh*)**, and **ܛܘܒ (*ṭūbā*)** vocabulary.

The study demonstrates that biblical “blessing” includes several related ideas: **bestowing benefit, invoking divine favor, praising God, pronouncing a benediction, being in a state of well-being, and being recognized as fortunate or blessed**. Psalm 1:1 is particularly important because its “blessed” does not use *bārak*, but **אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*)**, which describes the blessed condition of the person who lives according to God's way.

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1. Introduction

Few biblical words are as familiar as **bless** and **blessed**.

Christians commonly say:

“God bless you.”

Scripture says:

“Bless the LORD, O my soul.”

Psalm 1 begins:

“Blessed is the man…”

Jesus begins the Beatitudes with:

“Blessed are…”

Although the English vocabulary is similar, these passages do not necessarily use the same word in their original languages.

This distinction is important for biblical interpretation.

A word study must therefore ask:

1. What does **bless** mean in English?
2. What Hebrew words are translated “bless”?
3. What Hebrew word is translated “blessed” in Psalm 1?
4. What Greek words are translated “bless” and “blessed”?

5. What do Aramaic and Syriac traditions contribute?
6. How do these words function when **God blesses people**?
7. How do they function when **people bless God**?
8. What is the difference between **blessing someone** and **declaring someone blessed**?

These questions reveal that biblical blessing is considerably richer than the modern idea of simply “having good things.”

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2. The English Word “Bless”

The English verb **bless** generally means:

- to bestow favor or benefit;
- to invoke divine favor;
- to consecrate or make sacred;
- to praise or honor God;
- to pronounce a blessing upon another person.

The English adjective **blessed** can describe someone who has received blessing or someone who is considered fortunate, favored, or in a state of well-being.

This creates an important semantic distinction:

Bless

An **action**.

“God blesses Abraham.”

Blessed

A **condition or description**.

“Blessed is the man…”

English translations use the same word family for both concepts, but the original biblical languages sometimes employ different lexical roots.

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3. Hebrew Vocabulary

Because most of the Old Testament was written in Hebrew, Hebrew vocabulary provides the foundation for the Old Testament study.

Two words are especially important:

בָּרַךְ — *bārak*

and

אַשְׁרֵי — *’ashrê*

These should not be treated as synonyms in every context.

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4. Hebrew בָּרַךְ — *Bārak*

Hebrew

בָּרַךְ

Transliteration

bārak

Strong's

H1288

Part of speech

Verb.

The lexicon associates *bārak* with **blessing** and also with **kneeling/bowing**. It can describe blessing flowing from God toward people, blessing or praising God, and blessing between human beings.

4.1 God Blessing Humanity

One of the fundamental biblical uses occurs in creation.

Genesis 1:28 describes God blessing humanity and commanding fruitfulness and multiplication.

The idea of divine blessing therefore includes God's **bestowal of benefit and fruitfulness**.

The same vocabulary appears throughout the Old Testament in connection with God's covenantal dealings with His people.

4.2 Humans Blessing God

The direction can also be reversed.

The Bible repeatedly speaks of human beings **blessing the LORD**.

For example:

“Bless the LORD, O my soul…”

Human beings obviously do not give God material prosperity.

Therefore, in this context, *bārak* expresses **praise, adoration, thanksgiving, or acknowledgment of God's goodness**.

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon likewise records the cognate Aramaic use of *brk* for praising God or another deity.

4.3 The Concept of Kneeling

An interesting feature of *bārak* is its association with **kneeling or bowing**.

The lexical tradition records both the physical sense “to kneel” and the religious sense “to bless.”

This provides an important biblical-theological association:

Blessing is connected with submission, worship, and acknowledgment of God's greatness.

One should be cautious, however, about turning this lexical association into an absolute etymological explanation for every occurrence. Context determines meaning.

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5. Hebrew בְּרָכָה — *Berākhāh*

The noun related to *bārak* is:

בְּרָכָה

berākhāh

Meaning:

blessing

It can refer to a blessing received, a blessing pronounced, or a benediction.

The Hebrew *bārak* word-family therefore gives us the basic vocabulary of **blessing as an action and blessing as a bestowed benefit**.

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6. Hebrew אַשְׁרֵי — *’Ashrê*

Psalm 1:1 introduces a different word:

אַשְׁרֵי

’ashrê

This is one of the most important words for understanding the biblical idea of **“blessed.”**

Psalm 1:1 begins:

אַשְׁרֵי־הָאִישׁ
’ashrê-hā’îsh

Literally:

“Blessed is the man/person…”

The Septuagint translates this Hebrew expression with the Greek **μακάριος (*makarios*)**, showing how the Jewish Greek tradition understood the expression.

6.1 Meaning of *’Ashrê*

’Ashrê communicates the idea of:

- blessedness;
- happiness;
- fortunate condition;
- well-being;
- enviable or desirable state.

It is therefore useful to paraphrase Psalm 1:1:

“How blessed is the person…”

or:

“How fortunate is the person…”

The emphasis is not simply on an action God performs but on the **condition of the person**.

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7. *Bārak* and *’Ashrê*: An Essential Distinction

This distinction is fundamental.

Hebrew	Transliteration	Basic function
בָּרַךְ	*bārak*	To bless; an action
בְּרָכָה	*berākhāh*	Blessing
אַשְׁרֵי	*’ashrê*	Blessedness / fortunate condition

Therefore:

בָּרַךְ (*bārak*) = “to bless”

whereas:

אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*) = “blessed / how fortunate”

This explains why Psalm 1:1 should not simply be interpreted as:

“God blessed the man.”

The verse is announcing the **blessed condition of the person** who refuses the way of the wicked.

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8. Psalm 1:1 and the Meaning of Blessedness

Psalm 1 provides one of the clearest demonstrations of *’ashrê*.

The blessed person:

1. does not walk in the counsel of the ungodly;
2. does not stand in the way of sinners;
3. does not sit in the seat of the scornful/pestilence.

Then verse 2 gives the positive description:

His delight is in the law of the LORD.

The blessedness of Psalm 1 is therefore associated with a person's **orientation toward God's instruction**.

Verse 3 completes the picture by comparing the person to a tree planted beside water.

Thus:

Blessedness → delight in God's law → meditation → stability → fruitfulness.

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9. Greek Vocabulary

The New Testament uses several Greek words related to blessing.

Two major word families must be distinguished:

εὐλογέω — *eulogeō*

and

μακάριος — *makarios*

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10. Greek εὐλογέω — *Eulogeō*

Greek

εὐλογέω

Transliteration

eulogeō

Strong's

G2127

Part of speech

Verb.

The lexical meaning includes:

- to bless;
- to praise;
- to speak well of;
- to invoke blessing;
- to confer benefit.

The word is formed from **εὖ (*eu*)**, “well/good,” and **λόγος (*logos*)**, “word/speech.”

10.1 “To Speak Well”

The literal word formation provides the concept:

“to speak well.”

In biblical usage, however, *eulogeō* should not be reduced merely to making a nice statement.

It can describe the actual religious act of:

- blessing a person;
- praising God;
- giving thanks;
- pronouncing a blessing.

The New Testament uses the verb both for **God blessing people** and for **people blessing God**.

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11. Greek εὐλογία — *Eulogia*

The corresponding noun is:

εὐλογία

eulogia

Strong's

G2129

Meaning:

blessing, praise, benediction

It is the noun corresponding broadly to *eulogeō*.

The English word **eulogy** comes from the same Greek word family.

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12. Greek μακάριος — *Makarios*

The second major Greek term is:

μακάριος

makarios

Strong's

G3107

Part of speech

Adjective.

Its basic semantic range includes:

- blessed;
- fortunate;
- happy;
- in a favorable condition.

The term is especially prominent in the **Beatitudes** of Jesus.

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13. *Makarios* and the Beatitudes

Matthew 5 repeatedly says:

“Blessed are…”

The Greek adjective is **μακάριοι (*makarioi*)**, the plural form of *makarios*.

This is conceptually significant because Psalm 1 also begins with a declaration of blessedness.

The Septuagint renders Psalm 1:1:

Μακάριος ἀνήρ…
Makarios anēr…
“Blessed is the man…”

Therefore, there is a significant linguistic bridge between:

Psalm 1 → *’ashrê* → *makarios*

and

Jesus' Beatitudes → *makarios*.

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14. *Makarios* Is Not Merely an Emotion

A common mistake is to translate *makarios* simply as:

“feeling happy.”

The biblical usage is broader.

A person can be called blessed even when experiencing circumstances that would not normally be considered pleasant.

In the Beatitudes, for example, Jesus speaks of people experiencing poverty of spirit, mourning, persecution, and rejection.

Thus, biblical blessedness cannot be reduced to:

“I feel good because everything is going well.”

It refers to a person's **blessed or favorable standing/condition in relation to God**, rather than merely a temporary emotional state.

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15. Greek μακαρίζω — *Makarizō*

Another useful Greek term is:

μακαρίζω

makarizō

Strong's

G3106

Meaning:

to pronounce blessed; to declare happy or fortunate.

This is especially useful because it shows that Greek distinguishes between:

being blessed and

pronouncing someone blessed.

The vocabulary therefore contains both the state and the declaration of blessedness.

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16. Aramaic Vocabulary

Aramaic requires special care because “Aramaic” covers several historical dialects and traditions.

The Old Testament book of Psalms itself is Hebrew, not Aramaic.

However, **Biblical Aramaic, Jewish Aramaic, and Syriac** preserve closely related Semitic vocabulary and provide an important comparative perspective.

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17. Aramaic/Syriac בּרךְ — *Brk*

The Aramaic cognate of Hebrew *bārak* is:

ברך

brk

In Syriac it appears as:

ܒܪܟ

The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon records *brk* with meanings including:

- to bow;
- to bless;
- to praise God;
- to call down divine blessing upon a person;
- to recite a benediction;
- to provide in abundance.

This demonstrates the close relationship between the Hebrew and Aramaic blessing vocabulary.

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18. Aramaic “Blessed”

The Aramaic/Syriac tradition also has forms derived from the same root.

For example:

ܒܪܝܟ

brīkh

means:

blessed

The Aramaic/Syriac lexical tradition also has forms related to **blessing** and **being blessed**.

Thus the Hebrew and Aramaic traditions share an important cognate root:

Hebrew: ב־ר־ך
Aramaic: ב־ר־ך
Syriac: ܒ־ܪ־ܟ

The precise grammatical forms differ according to dialect and language stage.

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19. Aramaic/Syriac טוב — *Ṭūb*

Another important Syriac expression associated with blessedness is:

ܛܘܒܐ

ṭūbā

This word is associated with:

- goodness;
- blessedness;
- happiness;
- beatitude.

The Syriac lexicon gives forms such as:

ܛܽܘܒ݂ܹ **— ṭūbē**
“blessedness / beatitudes / happiness”

and expressions equivalent to:

“Blessed is he who…”

This vocabulary is particularly useful for comparison with the Greek **makarios** and Hebrew **’ashrê**.

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20. Two Aramaic Concepts

We therefore encounter two related but distinguishable ideas:

ברך / ܒ݁ܪ݂ܟ — *brk*

to bless, praise, invoke blessing

and:

ܛܽܘܒ݂ܳܐ **— *ṭūbā***

goodness, blessedness, happiness, beatitude

This parallels an important distinction already observed in Hebrew:

Blessing as an action
versus
Blessedness as a condition.

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21. Comparative Study

The major vocabulary can now be summarized:

Language	Word	Transliteration	Main grammatical function	Basic sense

English	bless	bless	Verb	Bestow/invoke blessing; praise
English	blessed	blessed	Adjective	Favored, fortunate, blessed
Hebrew	בָּרַךְ	*bārak*	Verb	To bless; bow/kneel
Hebrew	בְּרָכָה	*berākhāh*	Noun	Blessing
Hebrew	אַשְׁרֵי	*ʾashrê*	Blessedness expression	Blessed, fortunate, happy
Greek	εὐλογέω	*eulogeō*	Verb	Bless, praise, speak well
Greek	εὐλογία	*eulogia*	Noun	Blessing, benediction
Greek	μακάριος	*makarios*	Adjective	Blessed, fortunate
Greek	μακαρίζω	*makarizō*	Verb	Pronounce blessed
Aramaic/Syriac	ܒܪܟ / ברך	*brk*	Verb	Bless, praise, invoke blessing
Aramaic/Syriac	ܒܪܝܟ	*brīkh*	Adjective	Blessed
Aramaic/Syriac	ܛܘܒܐ	*ṭūbā*	Noun	Blessedness, happiness, goodness

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22. Blessing: Direction Matters

A particularly important conclusion from the word study is that **the direction of blessing affects the meaning**.

God → Humanity

God blesses people.

Meaning may include:

- favor;
- benefit;
- fruitfulness;
- protection;
- covenant blessing;
- provision.

Humanity → God

People bless God.

Meaning:

- praise;
- thanksgiving;
- worship;
- acknowledgment of God's goodness.

Person → Person

One person blesses another.

Meaning:

- pronouncing blessing;
- invoking God's favor;
- wishing or declaring good;
- giving a formal benediction.

The same English word therefore covers several related acts.

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23. Blessing Is More Than Material Prosperity

A biblical understanding of blessing must not be reduced to financial or material success.

Scripture can speak of blessing in terms of:

- God's presence;

- covenant relationship;
- wisdom;
- righteousness;
- fruitfulness;
- peace;
- protection;
- God's favor;
- spiritual inheritance;
- eternal life.

The Beatitudes demonstrate this particularly clearly.

Jesus can call a person **blessed** even when that person's outward circumstances include suffering.

Therefore:

Biblical blessedness is fundamentally relational and theological, not merely material.

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24. Blessing and Obedience in Psalm 1

Psalm 1 gives a particularly important example.

The Hebrew word is not *bārak* but:

אַשְׁרֵי — *'ashrê*

The blessed person is characterized by what he refuses and what he embraces.

He refuses:

the counsel of the ungodly,

the way of sinners,

the seat of the scornful.

He embraces:

the law of the LORD.

The result is:

“He shall be like a tree planted near the running waters.”

The imagery suggests stability, nourishment, fruitfulness, and life.

The blessed person is not merely someone who **possesses blessings**.

He is someone whose life is **rooted in the right source**.

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25. Psalm 1 and the Beatitudes

There is a remarkable conceptual connection between Psalm 1 and Matthew 5.

Psalm 1

“Blessed is the man…”

Matthew 5

“Blessed are…”

The Greek Septuagint renders Psalm 1:1 with:

μακάριος — *makarios*

the same major Greek word used in the Beatitudes.

Both passages use blessedness to introduce a description of the person who belongs to the way of God.

Psalm 1 emphasizes:

God's law, righteousness, and the two ways.

Jesus' Beatitudes emphasize:

God's kingdom, righteousness, mercy, purity, peacemaking, and perseverance.

The vocabulary therefore forms an important bridge between **Wisdom literature and the teaching of Jesus**.

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26. Blessing and the “Two Ways”

Psalm 1 is structured around two ways:

The way of the righteous

It is characterized by:

- delight in God's law;
- meditation;
- stability;
- fruitfulness;
- God's knowledge of the way.

The way of the wicked

It is characterized by:

- ungodliness;
- instability;
- judgment;
- ultimate destruction.

“Blessed” therefore introduces not merely a promise but a **way of life**.

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27. A Theological Definition

Based on the lexical evidence, a careful working definition can be proposed:

To bless

To bestow, invoke, pronounce, or acknowledge good and divine favor; when directed toward God, to praise and honor Him.

To be blessed

To exist in a condition of divine favor, goodness, well-being, or fortunate standing before God.

To pronounce someone blessed

To declare or recognize that person as enjoying a state of blessedness or divine favor.

These definitions preserve the distinctions found among the biblical languages.

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28. Important Translation Principle

No single English word can reproduce every nuance of the biblical vocabulary.

For example:

בָּרַךְ (*bārak*)

may be translated:

bless, praise, kneel, invoke blessing

depending on context.

Likewise:

אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*)

may be rendered:

blessed, happy, fortunate

depending on translation philosophy.

And:

μακάριος (*makarios*)

may communicate:

blessed, fortunate, happy.

Therefore, a responsible word study should never assume:

One English word = one biblical meaning.

Instead:

Meaning is determined by the original word, grammatical form, context, and theological setting.

29. Conclusion

The biblical concepts of **“bless”** and **“blessed”** are broader and richer than the ordinary modern use of the words.

The principal Hebrew verb **בָּרַךְ (*bārak*)** describes the act of blessing, including God's bestowal of benefit and human praise of God.

The Hebrew **אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*)**, especially important in Psalm 1:1, describes the **state of blessedness or fortunate well-being**.

The Greek **εὐλογέω (*eulogeō*)** emphasizes blessing, praising, and speaking well, while **εὐλογία (*eulogia*)** denotes blessing or benediction.

The Greek **μακάριος (*makarios*)** describes the **blessed or fortunate condition** and becomes the characteristic word of the Beatitudes.

Aramaic and Syriac preserve closely related **brk** vocabulary for blessing and also employ **ṭūb** vocabulary for goodness, happiness, and blessedness. The Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon documents *brk* both for blessing/praise and for calling down divine blessing, while Syriac sources distinguish *brk* vocabulary from *ṭūbā* vocabulary associated with blessedness and happiness.

The central conclusion is therefore:

“Bless” primarily describes an act—bestowing, invoking, pronouncing, or praising—while “blessed” can describe a condition of favor, well-being, fortunate standing, or recognized divine favor.

Psalm 1:1 illustrates the distinction beautifully.

The Hebrew does not use the ordinary verb *bārak* for “blessed.” It uses **אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*)**:

“Blessed is the man…”

The Septuagint renders this:

“Μακάριος ἀνήρ…” — “Blessed is the man…”

The blessed person is then defined not primarily by possessions, status, or outward prosperity, but by the **direction of his life**: he rejects ungodly counsel, delights in God's law, meditates upon it, and becomes like a fruitful tree planted beside water.

Thus the biblical concept of blessing ultimately points beyond **what a person has** to **how a person lives before God**.

Selected Lexical Sources

1. **Hebrew בָּרַךְ (*bārak*), Strong's H1288** — lexical data and biblical usage.
2. **Greek εὐλογέω (*eulogeō*), Strong's G2127** — "to bless, praise, speak well."
3. **Greek μακάριος (*makarios*), Strong's G3107** — "blessed, happy, fortunate."
4. **Septuagint, Psalm 1** — *'ashrê* rendered **μακάριος**.
5. **Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon** — *brk* vocabulary for bowing, blessing, praising, and invoking blessing.
6. **Syriac lexical evidence** — *brk* and *ṭūbā* vocabulary associated with blessing, blessedness, happiness, and beatitude.

Word Study: "Bless"

The English word **"bless"** is used frequently in the Bible, but the biblical languages use several different words that English translations may render as **bless** or **blessed**.

The most important distinction is between **blessing as an action** and **blessedness as a condition**.

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1. English: "Bless"

Bless — verb

To **bless** generally means:

- to bestow good upon
- to favor
- to invoke divine favor
- to praise or glorify God
- to make holy or consecrate
- to express gratitude to God

The meaning depends on **who is blessing whom**.

For example:

God blesses people
→ God bestows His favor, goodness, protection, or benefit.

People bless God
→ They praise, thank, honor, or speak well of God.

People bless other people
→ They may invoke God's favor upon them or pronounce a blessing.

Thus, “bless” does not always mean exactly the same thing in every biblical passage.

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2. Hebrew: בָּרַךְ — *Bārak*

One of the principal Hebrew words translated **“bless”** is:

בָּרַךְ

Transliteration: *bārak*
Pronunciation: approximately *bah-RAKH*

It is a **verb**.

Its basic meanings include:

to bless, kneel, or invoke blessing.

The related noun **בְּרָכָה (*berākhāh*)** means **blessing**.

This is the major Hebrew word to study when we encounter the biblical action:

“God blessed…”

Example: Genesis 1:28

“And God blessed them…”

The Hebrew verb is from the root:

ב־ר־ך (B-R-K)

God is the one performing the action of blessing.

Here, blessing is associated with God's **favor and the granting of fruitfulness**.

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3. When Humans “Bless God”

The Bible also speaks about people blessing God.

For example:

“Bless the Lord, O my soul…”
— Psalm 103:1

Obviously, human beings do not give God supernatural prosperity or increase.

Here **“bless” means to praise, honor, adore, and give thanks to God**.

Therefore:

God blesses humanity

God → person

God bestows blessing.

Humanity blesses God

person → God

The person praises and honors God.

The same English word **“bless”** can therefore describe two different directions of relationship.

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4. Greek: εὐλογέω — *Eulogeō*

A major New Testament Greek word translated **“to bless”** is:

εὐλογέω

Transliteration: *eulogeō*

It comes from:

εὖ (*eu*)
= good, well

and

λόγος (*logos*)
= word, speech

Literally, the word has the idea of:

“to speak well of.”

From this comes the English word:

Eulogy

A eulogy is literally associated with **speaking well of someone**.

In biblical usage, *eulogeō* can mean:

- to bless
- to praise
- to invoke blessing
- to give thanks
- to pronounce blessing

The context determines the precise sense.

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5. Greek: εὐλογία — *Eulogia*

The related noun is:

εὐλογία

Transliteration: *eulogia*

Meaning:

blessing

It can refer to:

- a blessing pronounced upon someone
- God's blessing
- a benefit or blessing received
- praise or thanksgiving

Thus:

εὐλογέω — *eulogeō*
→ to bless

εὐλογία — *eulogia*
→ blessing

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6. Hebrew “Bārak” vs. Hebrew “’Ashrê”

This distinction is especially important when studying Psalm 1.

בָּרַךְ — *bārak*

“to bless”

This is an **action**.

אַשְׁרֵי — *’ashrê*

“blessed”

This describes a **condition of blessedness or well-being**.

So:

Bārak = blessing as an action

while:

’Ashrê = blessedness as a condition

This is why Psalm 1:1 should not automatically be interpreted as:

“God blessed the man…”

The Hebrew wording is describing the **blessed condition of the man**.

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7. Blessing Is Not Simply Material Prosperity

A biblical study of “bless” should not reduce blessing to:

- money
- possessions
- physical comfort
- success
- popularity
- freedom from problems

The Bible uses blessing much more broadly.

God's blessing can involve:

- His presence
- His favor
- fruitfulness
- protection
- covenant relationship
- spiritual prosperity
- wisdom
- peace
- eternal life

A person can therefore be **blessed while experiencing hardship**.

This is particularly important when reading the Beatitudes of Jesus.

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8. Blessing and Obedience

Scripture frequently connects blessing with walking in God's ways.

Psalm 1 provides an excellent example.

The blessed person:

does not walk in ungodly counsel

and instead:

delights in the law of the Lord.

The result is pictured as:

“a tree which is planted near the running waters.”

Blessing, therefore, is connected with **relationship, obedience, spiritual nourishment, and fruitfulness**.

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9. A Simple Biblical Definition

Putting the major ideas together:

To bless

To bestow or invoke good and divine favor; to praise or honor God; or to pronounce a blessing, depending upon the direction and context.

To be blessed

To exist in a condition of divine favor, goodness, well-being, or spiritual flourishing.

Key Words to Remember

Language	Word	Meaning
English	**Bless**	Bestow favor; praise; invoke blessing

Hebrew	**בָּרַךְ — *bārak***	To bless
Hebrew	**בְּרָכָה — *berākhāh***	Blessing
Hebrew	**אַשְׁרֵי — *’ashrê***	Blessedness / fortunate condition
Greek	**εὐλογέω — *eulogeō***	To bless / speak well
Greek	**εὐλογία — *eulogia***	Blessing

One sentence to remember

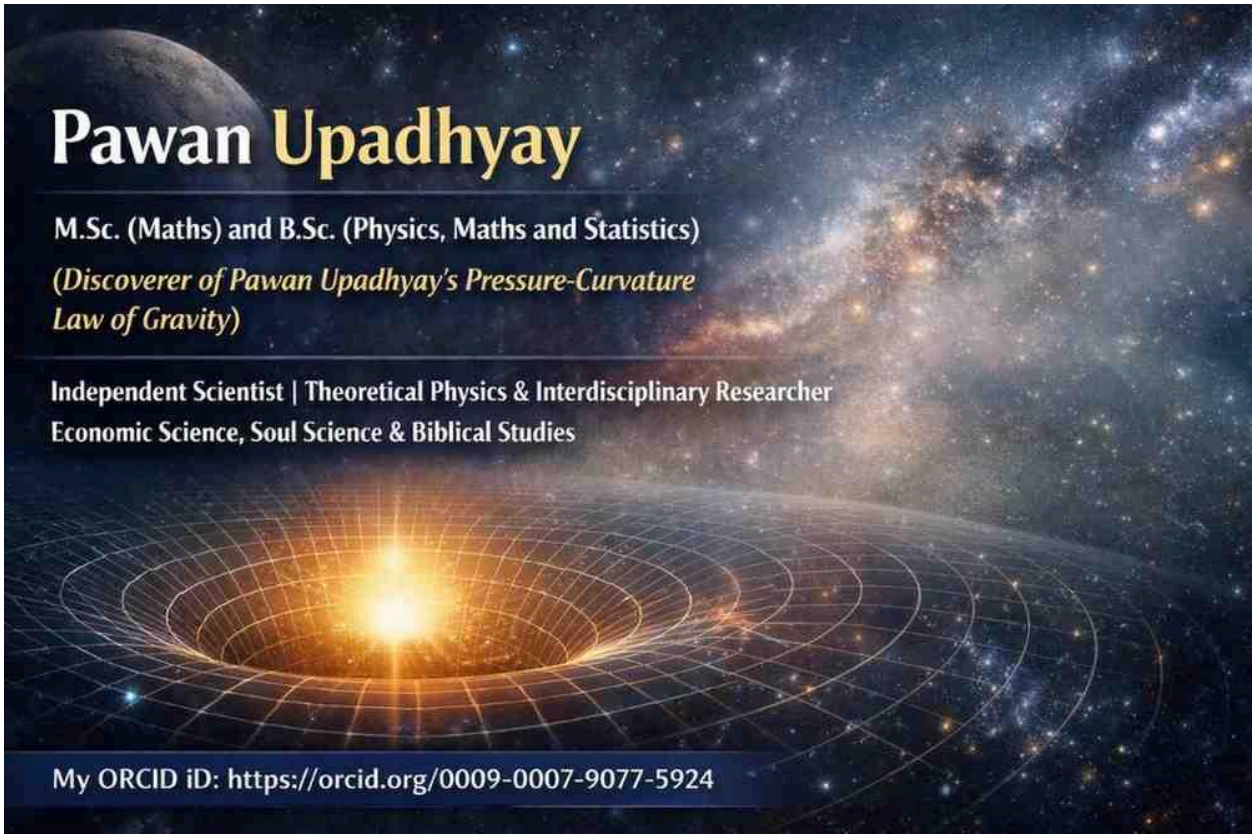
“To bless” is the action of bestowing, invoking, or declaring blessing; “blessed” can describe the resulting condition of favor, goodness, or well-being.

[Blog Version]

What Does “Blessed” Really Mean?

An English, Hebrew, Greek, and Aramaic Word Study of Psalm 1:1

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“Blessed is the man who hath not walked in the counsel of the ungodly, nor stood in the way of sinners, nor sat in the chair of pestilence.”
— Psalm 1:1, Douay-Rheims

The first word of Psalm 1 is one of the most important words in the entire psalm: **“Blessed.”**

We often use the word casually. We may say, “I am blessed,” meaning that something good has happened to us. But the biblical meaning is deeper. When we examine the word through **English, Hebrew, Greek, and Aramaic**, we see that biblical blessedness is not merely about material prosperity, pleasant circumstances, or temporary happiness.

Psalm 1 describes a person whose life is oriented toward God.

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1. The English Word: “Blessed”

The English word **blessed** can mean:

- favored
- fortunate

- happy
- enjoying well-being
- receiving God's favor
- living in a state of blessing

But English can sometimes hide an important distinction found in the original biblical languages.

When we read:

“Blessed is the man…”

we might immediately think:

“God has blessed this man.”

That idea can certainly be biblical in other contexts, but Psalm 1:1 is expressing something more specific.

The word describes the **condition of the person**.

It is essentially saying:

“How blessed is this person!”

or:

“How fortunate is the person who lives this way!”

The remainder of Psalm 1 explains what this blessed life looks like.

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2. The Hebrew Word: אַשְׁרֵי (*’Ashrê*)

Because Psalm 1 was originally written in Hebrew, the Hebrew word is especially important.

The opening words are:

אַשְׁרֵי־הָאִישׁ
’ashrê-hā’îsh

Literally:

“Blessed is the man/person…”

The key word is:

אַשְׁרֵי — *’ashrê*

It is associated with the Hebrew root **אשר (ʾ-sh-r)** and expresses the idea of **blessedness, happiness, good fortune, or well-being**.

It can carry the sense:

“How blessed!”
“How fortunate!”
“How happy!”
“O the blessedness of…”

This is significant because *’ashrê* is not simply the ordinary Hebrew verb “to bless.”

’Ashrê Is Different from *Bārak*

Another important Hebrew word translated “bless” is:

בָּרַךְ — *bārak*

Bārak is a verb meaning **to bless**.

But Psalm 1:1 uses:

אַשְׁרֵי — *’ashrê*

rather than:

בָּרַךְ — *bārak*

Therefore, Psalm 1:1 is not simply saying:

“God blessed the man.”

Instead, it presents the man as being in a **blessed or flourishing condition** because of the way he lives.

The psalm then explains why.

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3. What Makes the Man “Blessed”?

Psalm 1:1 gives three descriptions:

He does not walk in the counsel of the ungodly.

He refuses to make the thinking and advice of the wicked the guiding principle of his life.

He does not stand in the way of sinners.

He does not settle into a lifestyle that contradicts God's ways.

He does not sit in the chair of pestilence.

He does not establish himself among those who reject or mock what is good and godly.

Notice the progression:

Walk → Stand → Sit

The language can portray increasing involvement.

First, a person encounters ungodly counsel.

Then he stands in the way of sinners.

Finally, he sits down and becomes settled in that environment.

Psalm 1 therefore begins by showing us what the blessed person **does not allow to shape his life**.

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4. The Greek Word: Μακάριος (*Makarios*)

The Greek Old Testament, known as the **Septuagint**, translates the Hebrew concept of *'ashrê* with:

μακάριος — *makarios*

Makarios can mean:

- blessed
- fortunate
- happy
- in a privileged condition

- enjoying a state of well-being

The Greek word is especially familiar from the **Beatitudes of Jesus**.

For example:

“Blessed are the poor in spirit…”
— Matthew 5:3

The Greek word there is also **μακάριοι (*makarioi*)**, the plural form of *makarios*.

This creates an important connection between **Psalm 1** and **the Beatitudes**.

Psalm 1 begins:

“Blessed is the man…”

Jesus repeatedly begins His Beatitudes:

“Blessed are…”

In both cases, “blessed” describes a person who is in a particular relationship with God and His kingdom.

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5. Blessed Does Not Simply Mean “Feeling Happy”

Modern English can make “happy” sound primarily emotional.

For example:

“I am happy because I received good news.”

Biblical blessedness is deeper.

A person can experience sorrow, persecution, poverty, difficulty, or rejection and still be described as **blessed**.

This is particularly clear in Jesus' Beatitudes.

Therefore:

Blessedness is not identical to pleasant circumstances.

Psalm 1 is describing a person whose life is rightly oriented toward God.

The blessing is ultimately connected with **the person's relationship with God and God's ways**.

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6. The Aramaic/Syriac Perspective

Psalm 1 itself is Hebrew, not Aramaic.

Nevertheless, Aramaic and Syriac biblical traditions provide another valuable perspective on the concept.

A corresponding Syriac expression is:

ܛܽܘܒ݂ܰܝ — *ṭūbay(h)*

This expression communicates the idea of:

“Blessed is…”
“How fortunate…”
“How good it is for…”

The underlying Syriac root is associated with **ṭ-b**, carrying the idea of **goodness**.

This gives another interesting dimension to the biblical concept of blessedness: the blessed person is someone whose condition is genuinely **good or fortunate**, especially in relation to God's purposes.

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7. The Four Languages Together

We can summarize the basic comparison:

Language	Word	Basic idea

English	**Blessed**	Favored, fortunate, flourishing
Hebrew	**אַשְׁרֵי — *’ashrê***	How blessed/fortunate; state of well-being
Greek	**μακάριος — *makarios***	Blessed, fortunate, happy
Aramaic/Syriac	**ܛܽܘܒ݂ܰܝ — *ṭūbay(h)***	Blessed, fortunate, good condition

Although the languages are different, they converge around a central idea:

Biblical blessedness describes a person who is in a good and flourishing condition before God.

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8. The Positive Side of Psalm 1

Psalm 1 does not stop with what the blessed person avoids.

Verse 2 gives the positive description:

“But his will is in the law of the Lord, and on his law he shall meditate day and night.”

This is the heart of the psalm.

The blessed person does not merely avoid bad influences.

He develops a **delight in God's law**.

There is a movement:

Do not walk in ungodly counsel
↓
Delight in God's law
↓

Meditate on God's law
↓
Become like a fruitful tree
↓
Bear fruit in due season

Psalm 1 therefore presents blessedness as a **way of life**.

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9. The Tree Is the Picture of Blessedness

Psalm 1:3 gives the beautiful result:

“And he shall be like a tree which is planted near the running waters…”

The tree is:

- planted
- nourished
- fruitful
- stable
- alive
- productive

This is the picture of the blessed person.

Notice that Psalm 1 does not promise a life without difficulty.

Instead, it presents a life with a **deep source of nourishment**.

The person who delights in God's law is compared to a tree whose roots have access to water.

The external circumstances may change, but the source of life remains.

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10. What Does “Blessed” Mean in Psalm 1?

Putting the language study together, we can express the meaning this way:

“Blessed” in Psalm 1:1 describes the person who lives in the good and flourishing condition that comes from ordering his life according to God rather than according to the ways of the wicked.

It is more than:

“I have many good things.”

It is more than:

“I feel happy.”

And it is more than:

“God gave me material success.”

Biblical blessedness is fundamentally about **living rightly before God**.

Conclusion

The first word of Psalm 1 establishes the theme for the entire psalm:

“Blessed is the man…”

The Hebrew **אַשְׁרֵי (*’ashrê*)** points toward a state of blessedness, happiness, fortune, and well-being. The Greek **μακάριος (*makarios*)** carries a similar idea and becomes especially important in the Beatitudes of Jesus. Aramaic/Syriac expressions such as ܛܽܘܒ݂ܰܝ݂ **(*ṭūbay(h)*)** likewise communicate the idea of blessedness and fortunate condition.

But Psalm 1 gives us the clearest definition through the person's life.

The blessed person:

rejects ungodly counsel,
refuses the way of sinners,
does not settle among those who oppose God,
delights in God's law,
meditates upon it continually,
and becomes like a fruitful tree planted by water.

Therefore, Psalm 1 teaches that true blessedness is not merely about **what a person possesses**.

It is about **where a person is planted**.

And the blessed person is planted in the **Word and ways of God**.